Indeed, the nature of the challenges we faced predicate that India's analysis continuously monitors how the rest of the world is responding. Much of what the world faces today has come out of miscalculation on the part of some powers and its intelligent usage by others. But the course of history is far from linear, and even major nations are not impervious to becoming complacent or making errors. In fact, a common failing is to seek immediate gains at the cost of larger credibility. The realist, therefore, has to objectively analyse the state of play while being sceptical about the inevitability of events and trends. It is on this score that our epics may shed some light.

In world affairs, as indeed in human relationships, parties tend to help others out of goodwill, generosity or calculation. In real life, one can often spill into the other. The trigger of the Ramayana narrative is actually an act of exceptional trust, the two boons that King Dasaratha gave to his wife Kaikeyi on the battlefield. While involved in a war between the *asura* Sambara and the king of the gods Indra, Dasaratha was rescued by her when severely wounded in a night attack. It was these promises that Kaikeyi invoked to send Rama to his exile in the jungle and demand that her own son Bharata be crowned king.

If we consider the boons to be latent capabilities that were exercised when the time came, this episode is an object lesson on injudicious sharing. In recent decades, international relations have also witnessed how countries and economies were built up, perhaps less as an act of gratitude and more as one of utility. This was especially visible in the last years of the Cold War, when it came to exercising military and other pressures through third parties. But a lack of understanding of the players involved led to long-term consequences.

The Western world found that the Islamic card that it played against the USSR came back to haunt them within a decade. And when it comes to strategic understandings, the economic benefits that China obtained became the foundation for the upturning of the global order and the contemporary competition that we witness now. India, too, carries the consequences of its own past dealings. Its strong advocacy of Chinese interests in the 1950s was obviously not repaid in kind. It is bad enough to forget that gratitude has a short shelf-life in diplomacy; it is even more so when basics of diplomatic calculation are overridden by misplaced beliefs of political solidarity.

In personal terms, vulnerabilities are often created as a result of thoughtlessness. On occasion, it could also be an emotional response to a challenge. To some degree, that could be extrapolated to explain the behaviour of nation-states as well. But a more credible explanation can be found in the mindset of strategic complacency that polities and rulers often display.

A telling example is the case of the key antagonist, the demon-king Ravana of Lanka. In that era, exceptional figures performed the most exacting penance that could be rewarded by their wishes being granted by the Gods. In this case, Ravana was given the boon of invincibility by the creator Brahma. But in his arrogance, he invoked it only against what he saw as likely threats, *devas* and *gandharvas*, *asuras* and *kinnaras*, *nagas* and *rakshasas*, all creatures other than men. He left out humankind because he could not even envisage that such puny beings could be threatening. And it was for that reason that Lord Vishnu took a human form, that of Lord Rama, to kill Ravana.